

How to Improve Your Memory

Once we understand learning and recall, research shows that we can find ways to boost these processes and improve our memories. Some of the best memory techniques, such as the memory palace, are actually some of the oldest.

Often, when we “forget” something, we haven’t stored it properly in the first place. To avoid this, we must process information deeply—paying full attention to what we are learning, thinking about it, and seeing how it links to other things we already know.

Once stored, we need to make sure the information stays put, by practicing or repeating whatever we are trying to learn. The more often we activate pairs of neurons together, the stronger that connection becomes and the more likely we are to remember it in the future. The spacing of repetitions is important, too—it is better to revise for 10 minutes a day for six days than one hour on a single day.

The power of cues and rest

There are techniques we can use to help recall information, and many of them rely on cues. These triggers can be internal, such as mnemonics, which provide the first letters of a list of items, cuing recall of the items themselves. Or they can be

external—such as the scent of freesias taking you back to your wedding day. The memory palace technique uses associations and triggers to help recall long lists of information in order.

Probably the most important thing we can do for our memories is get enough sleep. If we are tired, our focus and attention suffer, and the brain just isn’t in the right state to learn. Sleep is also vital after learning for memories to be consolidated, sorted, and stored.

Here is a quick recap of how to boost your memory:

- **Process the information deeply.**
- **Rehearse it regularly.**
- **Use cues and associations.**
- **Get plenty of sleep.**

Using a memory palace

Imagine you are walking through somewhere familiar, such as your house. At strategic points, visualize objects relating to the words you hope to remember, such as the items on a shopping list. To recall the list, simply “walk” the route again – the objects act as triggers.

